



FAMILY COURT DATA REPORT · STATE SERIES · NO. 15

ILLINOIS

WHAT FAMILIES ARE REPORTING.

Pulled from the Family Rights Registry — the first cross-state dataset on what pro se parents are actually experiencing inside Illinois's family courts and child-welfare system.

100

ILLINOIS FAMILIES ON RECORD · 146
CHILDREN IMPACTED · 15 MONTHS
MEDIAN MONTHS LOST OF PARENTING
TIME

REPORT GENERATED
MAY 13, 2026

COUNTIES REPRESENTED
36 OF 102

COMPILED BY
MEG · STANDWITHMEG.COM

THE HEADLINE NUMBERS

ILLINOIS AT A GLANCE.

Across 100 Illinois families reporting through the Family Rights Registry, the patterns are consistent: long durations in court, serious financial loss, and a disproportionate number of parents going unrepresented because they ran out of money fighting.

CHILDREN IMPACTED 146 99 of 100 families reported child counts	MEDIAN FAMILY BURDEN \$132,000 median across 59 families reporting 3+ categories	MEDIAN MONTHS LOST 15 of parenting time	WENT PRO SE 49.0% 34.0% after running out of money
SUBMISSIONS 100	AVG CHILDREN / FAMILY 1.5	FAMILIES REPORTING CHILDREN 99 of 100	COUNTIES REPRESENTED 36

WHY THIS REPORT EXISTS.

On January 29, 2024, I lost custody of all five of my children.

- NO TRIAL.
- NO QUESTIONING.
- NO SUBSTANTIATED ABUSE.

It took only a signature on an ex parte emergency order to erase a mother. I refused to disappear. I fought back, and built the Family Rights Registry so Illinois families — and families in every state — would stop being invisible to the data. This report is their record.

— MEG · [STANDWITHMEG.COM](https://standwithmeg.com)

02 THE COST OF ILLINOIS FAMILY COURT

Legal fees are the largest reported expense, but they are not the only one. Lost wages, evaluation costs, and reunification services compound the financial loss — pushing most families toward pro se representation once their savings run out.

EXPENSE CATEGORY	RESPONSES	MEDIAN	MEAN	TOTAL REPORTED
Attorney Fees	71	\$20,000	\$72,800	\$5,168,800
Lost Wages	64	\$22,000	\$94,500	\$6,048,000
Other Court Fees	33	\$550	\$4,814	\$158,850
Therapy / Evaluations	47	\$2,500	\$6,053	\$284,480
Reunification Services	36	\$500	\$1,776	\$63,925
GAL Fees	60	\$5,000	\$12,103	\$726,200
Asset Loss ¹	49	\$30,000	—	—
Median Family Burden (59 families reporting 3+ categories)	—	\$132,000	—	—

Median vs. mean: Median is the middle reported amount, so it better reflects the typical reporting family when a few very large expenses appear. Mean is the average across reporting families and can be pulled higher by outliers. **Median Family Burden** is the median of total reported expenses across families who reported costs in 3 or more expense categories with a combined total of at least \$1,000 — a true median of real family totals, restricted to families who filled out enough of the financial section to characterize their case and excluding obvious data-entry artifacts.

1. On asset loss: One respondent reported an extreme outlier that skews the mean beyond usefulness. We report the median (\$30,000) and suppress the mean and total, pending data-quality review. Lost Wages also contains wide variance; median is the honest headline.

LOST PARENTING TIME · MONTHS

Median months lost		15	1.2 yrs
Mean months lost		27	2.2 yrs
Total across all families		1,725	143.8 yrs

03 WHO IS REPORTING · ILLINOIS

Most families documenting in Illinois are currently active in, or recently closed out of, long-running cases. Nearly half have lost all contact with their children.

CASE STATUS · SYSTEM AFFECTED

CASE STATUS

Active case: stuck or delayed		59	59%
Not provided		18	18%
Case closed: more than 2 years ago		9	9%
Case closed: within last 2 years		7	7%
Not in court but still affected		3	3%

SYSTEM AFFECTED

Family Court Only		41	41%
Both Family Court and CPS		39	39%
CPS (Child Protective Services) Only		10	10%
Unknown		9	9%
Child Protective Services (CPS / DCF)		1	1%

DURATION · CUSTODY OUTCOMES

TIME IN SYSTEM

1 – 3 years		23	23%
3 – 5 years		20	20%
5 – 10 years		20	20%
Over 10 years		14	14%
6 months – 1 year		9	9%

CUSTODY STATUS

No Contact / Total Loss of Access		30	30%
Visitation Only		21	21%
50/50 Joint		19	19%
Children in Foster Care		10	10%
Full Custody		10	10%

GEOGRAPHY · ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

TOP COUNTIES

Cook		15	15%
Madison		5	5%
Lake		5	5%
Will		4	4%
Kane		4	4%
Sangamon		3	3%

TOP ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

Family Court False Accusations (Domestic Violence/Abuse/Alienation)		33	33%
High Conflict Divorce		18	18%
False Accusations CPS (Non-Medical) (Vengeful ex-partner, malicious report)		12	12%
Other: (Short answer)		9	9%
Other		4	4%

04 PARENT VOICES — ILLINOIS

Selected voice excerpts appear here for readability. Every approved, shareable Illinois comment is printed in full in the appendix that follows.



Illegally refuse to return my children due to false allegations and put my children in harm's way and cause them physical sexual and emotional abuse

— KRYSTAL BRIDGEMAN

ON THE REPORTED ALLEGATIONS

I have provided sufficient evidence from how my children were not wanting to see their father due to emotional neglect, verbal abuse, blamed children for the conflict between him and his girlfriend. Children left stranded by the girlfriend when my ex husband and girlfriend got [...]

— ILLINOIS PARENT · ANONYMOUS

MORE VOICES FROM ILLINOIS

Destroyed every chance of me having a normal life and family. Cause my kids trauma and heartbreak they should have never been through

— HOLLY

The judge and opposing attorney covered up sexual abuse that my ex-boyfriend did my two children. The court, and the opposing attorney and the prosecutor contrived child abduction against me, made it appear as if I was not even the mother or sole custodial parent of my children. [...]

— MISTY

They have terminated my rights cps in illinois is major corrupted even when all services were completed they still Adopted my children out to a women who could have children and was close to a caseworker

— ELIZABETH

Family court has destroyed the innocence and robbed the dreams of my children and my motherhood. Family court has become the abuser and the weapon of my abuser. Family court is responsible for creating poverty homelessness and generational trauma.

— STEPHANIE

04 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



Dcfs the Chicago police the cook county public Guardians office and the cook county states Attorneys office along with the Attorney General's office violated all of my family's civil rights and my children suffered horrible irreparable physical damage for 16 years without a [...]

— JERRY

The system has terrorized and tortured me. They have stolen my son, my kids brother. And they have created lifelong scars that will never heal.

— LAUREN

Dcfs took my children during covid. I've missed out on so much, they ruined our lives.

— JENNA

The courts and GAL have allowed my ex to use the children to try to hurt me and have destroyed a happy healthy relationship I had with my boys. The court has and still is illegally taking disability income for things other than child support under threat of jail.

— DEREK

It has destroyed my life and my child is suffering in the hands of our abuser.

— LINSI

This system has deprived me and my children's rights and destroyed my family. There is nothing that can bring back the time they stole with my children.

— JENNY

This system has consistently abused me, gaslighted me, slandered me, assassinated my character. All while the judge looked me right in the eyes and said you're not a victim here. My children and I will never recover from the damage done. We can only hope to pick up the pieces [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Separated a two parent family from a child over false allegations. I am an indigent american veteran with not income for over a year fighting for my benefits. They have destroyed me financially knowing I have no income.

— THOMAS

The system has destroyed two children and maybe more as a sexual predator has access to the children's friends who he has started giving gifts to which he hides in his room. The GAL threaten my withness with fostercare if she didnt go back to her abuser now my child talks [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

04 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



Destroyed my hopes & my dreams. Took away the only thing I ever wanted to be the most of and that was being the best mother I could be to my girls. My life was flipped upside down over night. I had idea my baby daddy was working with CPS behind my back.

— JENNIFER

It's completely destroyed us both emotionally and physically.

— AMANDA

It has failed me from being a parent to my kids when I had done nothing wrong. My mother has paid off judges and lawyers to help take my children from me. She made friends with the mayor of the town and his wife going and having dinners with them, she made friends with the [...]

— KAYLA

Enable the abuser to continue using our child as a pawn

— MELISSA

This corrupt system has broken, stole, lied, and humiliated my family.

— AMANDA

Destroyed everything. Scarred my child.

— CAITLYN

Severe PTSD for me and trauma for my children. Tragically limited the potential of my children's future from what it could have been.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Kidnapped our 3 children and drove my wife 2 hours away for a psych evaluation while I was out of town for business

— BRANDON

Losing my 2 oldest was the hardest not being hear in my youngest case is even worse I currently have only one case going in family court and my mental health is still used against me. If there was a way to get all my kids back I would but IL is so corrupt and I get turned down [...]

— HANNAH

04 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



Do not file anything in regard to abuse of a mother or child in Mchenry county especially if the father has stalked you. The judges gals and attorneys all align together against you. They talk openly about each case with each other between recesses in front of me! The system is [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Let's just that there are no words to describe what the system has done to my kids and I. Just no words at all.

— HOLLY

The system has fabricated false allegations, violated my constitutional rights, and blackmailed me or blackballed me into taking a Alfred please or no contest that I never wanted to accept and even made it known on the record.

— DAN

I am absolutely destroyed. All I do is cry for my child. I can't eat or sleep. The system has ruined my life. I am in law enforcement and question our legal system to the point where I no longer believe in the child civil side of it and Divorce side

— JASON

Caused us separation anxiety due to family disruption.. trauma pain.. health problems

— CHERRY

Destroyed time cannot ge5 nack.

— KATE

The family court ecosystem specifically provided over by the second judge in my dissolution, deprive me of my peace, my joy, my health, my reputation, my assets, my stability, my future. I got my kids back on my own.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

I don't know where to begin, the system has failed my children and me to our rights. Has put me in a depression state has stolen time and money from our family. It has broken my trust in all this I will never come to the court for help because of the unfairness they cause in [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

I have lost the daily relationship eith my only child. She is 4 and they forced her to stay with her abuser.I am only allowed to have 1 supervised visit for 1 hour a week only. I lost my job,car apartment and had to file bankruptcy.

— GINA

04 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



They didn't just take my children from me, they took my stability, my time, my peace, my reputation, my ability to work, my trust in people, and two years of my life I can never get back."

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

My caseworker has not only erased me, she nearly has buried me.

— MISTY

It's made my faith in Christ impenetrable. I believe in his promise—all things work together for the good of those who love the Lord.

— KATIE

Mentally kidnapped my kids

— RYAN

Broken me, making my daughter hate me, putting alot of stress on my current family

— JOSE

It has taken way my son who does child from our family and her sisters

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Has destroyed our family and left my son morning the disappearance of his father, grandfather, grandmother, ants ,uncles and his cousins and all his friends. We are morning a child that is still alive.

— VICTOR

DEVISTATED the family , ruined our lives

— ANDREA

Split family, kept father from child for 1 year Child trauma

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Post separation abuse from my ex, refusal to hold him accountable for violating court orders

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Ruined my life & taken time away me nor my family will never get back. TRAMATIZED US

— SAMANTHA

70 Illinois parents submitted approved, shareable comments. 44 selected excerpts appear here; the full comments begin on the next page.

05 FULL PARENT COMMENTS — ILLINOIS

The comments below are the full approved, publicly shareable survey comments from Illinois families. Data-only and do-not-share submissions are excluded from this public appendix.

Illegally refuse to return my children due to false allegations and put my children in harm's way and cause them physical sexual and emotional abuse

— **KRYSTAL BRIDGEMAN**

Destroyed every chance of me having a normal life and family. Cause my kids trauma and heartbreak they should have never been through

— **HOLLY**

The judge and opposing attorney covered up sexual abuse that my ex-boyfriend did my two children. The court, and the opposing attorney and the prosecutor contrived child abduction against me, made it appear as if I was not even the mother or sole custodial parent of my children. They used that crime that they falsified to steal my children from me and keep them from me. There was never a custody hearing, there was no custody switch. It was just their contrived crime. There was no GAL. The judge would not allow a GAL.

— **MISTY**

They have terminated my rights cps in illinois is major corrupted even when all services were completed they still Adopted my children out to a women who could have children and was close to a caseworker

— **ELIZABETH**

Family court has destroyed the innocence and robbed the dreams of my children and my motherhood. Family court has become the abuser and the weapon of my abuser. Family court is responsible for creating poverty homelessness and generational trauma.

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This system has consistently abused me, gaslighted me, slandered me, assassinated my character. All while the judge looked me right in the eyes and said you're not a victim here. My children and I will never recover from the damage done. We can only hope to pick up the pieces and move forward

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

05 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

I have provided sufficient evidence from how my children were not wanting to see their father due to emotional neglect, verbal abuse, blamed children for the conflict between him and his girlfriend. Children left stranded by the girlfriend when my ex husband and girlfriend got into an argument and ex husband proceeded to yell at the children that it is the kids fault kept the children in the cold yelling outside. Children called the police and there is a police report that the kids stated that they were afraid, and threatened. statement from my son stating that father was doing drugs such as shrooms GAL was notified and ignored. Son was administrated marijuana and statement was given by my son to the principal that his father gave him weed.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Separated a two parent family from a child over false allegations. I am an indigent american veteran with not income for over a year fighting for my benefits. They have destroyed me financially knowing I have no income.

— THOMAS

The system has destroyed two children and maybe more as a sexual predator has access to the children's friends who he has started giving gifts to which he hides in his room. The GAL threaten my withness with fostercare if she didnt go back to her abuser now my child talks sexually with adult men online and I was told that I monitor her to closely and was told I could not monitor them. I am a cyber security engineer who has worked on child monitoring apps for fortune 10 companies.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Destroyed my hopes & my dreams. Took away the only thing I ever wanted to be the most of and that was being the best mother I could be to my girls. My life was flipped upside down over night. I had idea my baby daddy was working with CPS behind my back.

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It has failed me from being a parent to my kids when I had done nothing wrong. My mother has paid off judges and lawyers to help take my children from me. She made friends with the mayor of the town and his wife going and having dinners with them, she made friends with the sheriff and cops and any one who was elite and of importance. She talked bad about me to my community and I couldn't even go into a grocery store and hold my head up high because everyone was giving me looks. My kids love me and my mom is brain washing my kids into thinking I'm a bad mom and that she is their mom now. It has tore me and my kids life apart. I have two other daughters now and they don't get to see or be involved

— KAYLA

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— HANNAH

Do not file anything in regard to abuse of a mother or child in Mchenry county especially if the father has stalked you. The judges gals and attorneys all align together against you. They talk openly about each case with each other between recesses in front of me! The system is rigged in favor of the criminals. Do not file anything abuse related in Mchenry County or risk losing your child. The only reason I didn't lose my child completely is bc I learned to play the game protect my case with a crazy amount of intuition determination and grit.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

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— ANONYMOUS PARENT

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— KATIE

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— SAMANTHA

05 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

Alienation of my Children

— JUSTIN

Made us out to be the bad guy without looking into anything

— CHRISTY

Ripped my family apart. Caused conflict and abandonment with my family. Prolonged my ppd and made me go through pain from c-section due to not filling my prescription for pain medication in fear that a dirty test regardless of prescription would cause devastating damage.

— REBECCA

Caused stress in the household constantly watching who we talk to and what's said.

— CHRISTY

Judge listened to ex parte communication from stepmom which she filed a third party intervenor to my divorce case after my ex has died. Put a false Order of Protection against me with no hearing until it was dismissed a year later by my lawyer. My ex husband worked with everyone in the same courthouse Im fighting for my daughter.

— KATHLEEN

With getting out of the abuse I really feel like my voice was never heard and told that I have to still communicate and work with this person and forced to hand over my baby to this person weekly even if he takes him for weeks with out a known address

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Maliciousness has caused financial, physical and emotional harm. Harm to child involved

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

05 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

The psychological and financial abuse should be considered family terrorism because thats EXACTLY what it is. They terrorize you mentally then extort your hard earned money and savings on the "best interest of the child." The years of therapy I have been through has only made it somewhat bearable.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

A judge suspended all of my parenting time with my son, relief no one asked for, despite every single evaluator opposing restriction, no finding of endangerment, and a written order acknowledging my conduct didn't warrant professional intervention; my child was taken not because I failed him, but because a system with no accountability decided it could.

— STAVROS

taken everthing away from me and my childs current and future

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The family court system has caused irreparable damage to my young children. We can never get their childhood back. They are continually punished for things over which they have no control. God will provide justice in the end.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Dehumanized and robbed us, then asked to pay for it.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Yeah, the system has refused to adjudicate one fact in every single case in every single file and every single quote while acting on allegations in here say without any factual evidence from the other side and I'm not exaggerating

— JEFFREY

05 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

Has ripped my teenage daughter away placed her in behavior hospital where she's mentally declined because no placement so she's imprisoned against will drugged daily and begs to come home the PTSD inflicted will cause her to never ask for help and our case warranted a intact get your crap together first but they chose removal

— BOBBIE

Having to grieve the loss of children that aren't dead is something that can't be put into words. The pain is unbearable but you have to survive in case they come back...it's a horrible way to live.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The system is taking my 5 year old daughter from her mother and siblings on fake alienation claims without viewing any of my children's sexual anuse evidence

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The damage to my family is catastrophic. Its been 9 years of torment. My youngest son was only 2 yrs old, and I've been told he doesn't remember me and thinks my exes current wife is his mom and they let him think so. Hes 11 years old now. Ive haven't seen my daughter either and I have no idea if she remembers me at all. My oldest is 22 now and we are just beginning to have a relationship. I am grateful for that but I mourn the relationship we used to have, the one we should have, the one we deserve to have. None of us are the people we would have been, we are all more broken, all more damaged, changed, robbed of our rightful place in each other's lives and not one person is better for it. A family destroyed for nothing.

— AMBER

Put me to the brink of death or wanting to kill

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

The system failed me as a child in the welfare system, at 30 years old seeing no real change, accountability or resources while my children are now in DCFS custody is quite scary, they're understaffed and not held accountable. We now live in fear waiting for reunification, in which we have been targets of DCFS since 2019.

— STARKESHIA

05 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

I will never get my sons and daughters back in the same condition as when they were taken. Sadly, they too have lost the mother they were kidnapped from.

— MONIQUE

I recently read the quote “blessed that I was chosen to raise these beautiful souls.” And I had to take a step back emotionally because no ounce of me feels chosen to be a mother by this court. Parents are recognizing that we have done all we can to escape the abuse and heal but now we are opening our eyes to a system built upon greed. We have faith that what is done in the dark will come to light.

— CRISTINA

I have made it to the other side, my fear is that it will take my son a long time to heal from the emotional damage. I have NEVER lost my faith in God and he has carried me through.

— TIFFANY

It cost me my whole world. I made mistakes and I take full responsibility for them but people can change and learn from their mistakes and I've done that. They are using my past and my prior cases and court involvement as a reason for me to not be able to parent now and I truly believe they are in the wrong. I'm a great mother and I love my kids. What they are doing isn't right and they are causing more damage by putting such a young baby who only knows his mom and dad into a foster home with complete strangers.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Over years of litigation and ongoing conflict, the family court process and my ex's conduct have created instability, severe emotional strain, and division within our family, placing the children in the middle of adult issues instead of protecting their emotional, mental and physical wellbeing. The repeated litigation, financial instability, interference with parenting time, and ongoing conflict have significantly impacted both me and the children emotionally, mentally, physically, financially, and relationally, while undermining consistency and security for the children.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

05 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

Services with held not offered in a timely manner ended up losing parental Fitness and one trial have to pay child support on the other three don't even get a joint custody or visitation schedule for the other3

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

My daughters repeatedly ask for mom. I've seen my oldest daughter's school portal where she writes letters to me that she isn't allowed to send. Her doctor has reached out to me asking why her father hasn't brought her to her regular checkups for her medical condition. He lies and says she resides with him when eyewitnesses have stated they have seen all other members of his family except do my daughter. My youngest (with the other man who is now my ex's bff) is confined to a playroom, is in full time year round daycare while her father sits unemployed in a million dollar home asking me for child support (i work part time and rely on family help). I watch as he tells her that she is happy after she expresses she had a bad day or is sad. She has said she doesn't have friends.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

70 full approved Illinois comments are included in this appendix.

06 HOW TO READ THIS REPORT

WHAT THIS IS

The Family Rights Registry is a national, parent-reported data collection run by Stand With Meg. Every figure in this Illinois report comes from Illinois respondents who voluntarily submitted survey entries about their experience inside family court and/or CPS.

This report is built to help families, advocates, reporters, and legislators see the patterns emerging in Illinois — not to replace formal research, and not to name individual judges or counties as responsible parties.

WHAT IT ISN'T

This is not a representative sample. Respondents self-select. The 100 Illinois families reporting here are not the universe of Illinois families in court — they are the families who found the survey, trusted it enough to submit, and told us what happened to them.

Financial figures are self-reported. We flag outliers and report medians when means are distorted (see page 3, note 1). The Median Family Burden headline is the median of total reported expenses across families who reported in three or more expense categories. Quotes are minimally edited.

METHODOLOGY · FAMILY RIGHTS REGISTRY

Data in this report was collected April 2024 – May 2026 through standwithmeg.com/family-rights-survey. Submissions are timestamped. Duplicate-submission heuristics use normalized email + location, with direct survey rows preferred over legacy rows and the newest row retained within each source. Categorical responses from multi-select and short-answer fields are normalized monthly.

When a respondent's financial entry differs from the population by more than three standard deviations, the mean is suppressed and only the median is reported. Lost-wage, attorney-fee, and asset-loss entries are self-reported and not corroborated against tax records or court filings.

Geographic reporting uses the county field as submitted, with light normalization (e.g. "Butte silverbow" → "Butte–Silver Bow"). Quotes carry one of three public permission states: *Anonymous*, *First-name only*, or *Full attribution with consent to public use*. Court actor names appear only after 3 independent families name the same actor.

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ABOUT THIS REPORT

This report is based on self-reported survey submissions collected by Stand With Meg. Counts and categories reflect responses available at the time this packet was generated.

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